

AFTER

The site of the battle was a small, low hillside just outside Prague where 23,000 Austrian imperial and Catholic forces faced about 21,000 Protestants of the Bohemian Estates' army and the Czech nobility under Frederick V, king of Bohemia.

Imperial forces outnumbered the Estates forces, though the latter had well-trained mercenaries and the advantage of being on higher ground.

The Estates army formed two echelons of footsoldiers, about 5,000 cavalry, and reserves. The right wing flanked an arboretum, the left backed against a hillock.

Blocks of troops were typical of this period: being less spread out, they were easier to command. However, any accurate artillery shell or side-on cavalry charge on such a formation spelled disaster, as the target was larger.



were publicly slung out of Hradšchin Castle windows onto the moat some 50 ft (15 m) below, although they were unharmed.

With the election, on Matthias's death in 1619, of Ferdinand as King of Bohemia and Holy Roman Emperor, the Habsburg's religious issues became an imperial one. The Bohemian rebels appointed Calvinist Frederick V as king of Bohemia; he took the throne and called for support from the Protestant Union in his revolt. Spain lent Ferdinand financial aid, as well as troops, which, together with the newly mustered Catholic League army led by Count Tilly, marched into Bohemia to crush the German Protestant rebellion.

After the battle of White Mountain on November 8, 1620 (see above), Bohemia lost its independence, and Protestantism in the region was exterminated.

Murky motives

Various countries supported the cause of the Protestants for their own ends, political or territorial, entering into war with the Habsburgs at different times. Cardinal Richelieu of Catholic France supported the rights of the German princes against the Catholic Habsburgs, led by state politics and trading interests rather than any shared cause.

Self-interest of the sovereign state was also behind the intervention of the Dutch Republic and Sweden in the war, rather than any anti-Catholic solidarity with the German protestants. The Dutch had trading rights to protect across Europe and the rest of the world.

Sweden was a small country of peasant farmers and a preeminent gun foundries industry. Under the decisive leadership of Gustavus Adolphus II (see p.272), Sweden became a power on the Baltic coast. Having crushed Count Tilly at the Battle of Breitenfeld in 1631,

Gustavus was killed at the ensuing battle of Lützen in 1632. The desire for peace, and resentment against marauding armies looting their land, was now overwhelming in Germany, and the Peace of Prague was forged in 1635 between the Holy Roman Empire and most Protestant states.

Reconciliation between Catholics and Protestants in Germany was imminent, but Richelieu, displeased to see the Habsburgs retain power, entered into the war against them that year, with Swedish support.

The theater of war now spread to most of Europe, with fighting between the Dutch Republic and France against Spain. With the Treaty of Westphalia in 1648 Habsburg power in Europe was fatally checked.

By the end of the 30 Years War, there had been a shift in power among the states involved and a framework for a modern Europe of sovereign states was established.

EMERGENCE OF SOVEREIGN STATES

The Peace of Westphalia paved the way for the concept of the sovereign state. **Fixed geographical boundaries** for the many countries involved were established and states of the Holy Roman Empire were **granted full sovereignty**. It was recognized that citizens were bound to the laws of their own government rather than those of neighboring powers, whether religious or secular.

THE RISE OF FRANCE

The end of the war left Germany decentralized and divided into many territories. A politically weakened Spain recognized the Dutch Republic—and later Portugal—as independent. France continued to war with Spain until 1659, when it emerged as the **dominant Western power**.

RELIGIOUS TOLERANCE

Calvinism, Lutheranism, and Catholicism were all recognized as **legitimate faiths**. While religious conflicts still occurred, there were no further great religious wars in mainland Europe.

DECLINE OF THE MERCENARY

The hiring of mercenaries had been commonplace in realms that lacked standing armies. However, the size of these armies had grown massively, making them **very costly to maintain**. They also caused great destruction as the soldiers attempted to live off the land, often taking from civilians. These limitations gave rise to the idea of the national "professional" army.

7 MILLION The estimated number of dead in the 30 Years War. It was the most costly war in terms of human life to be fought on European soil until the two world wars of the 20th century.



Peace of Westphalia

Signed on October 24, 1648, this document ended the 30 Years War, establishing that more than one religion could coexist in Habsburg Europe.